

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Harish Hande, Co-founder, SELCO India & SELCO Foundation

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact leaders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad, where we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs who have built impactful institutions from the ground up.

In today's episode, we have the privilege of speaking with Mr. Harish Hande, a visionary engineer, social entrepreneur, and one of India's foremost champions of energy equity. Harish co-founded SELCO India in 1995, with the singular belief that the rural world deserved access to clean, sustainable energy — and that they were entirely capable of paying for it, given the right financing models. Over nearly three decades, SELCO has brought solar energy solutions to over 750,000 underserved households and livelihoods across India, shattering the myth that poverty and sustainability are incompatible. The SELCO Foundation, which Harish now leads, goes further still — building an ecosystem of grassroots innovation, incubation, and policy influence to make clean energy a reality for the last mile.

Harish holds a PhD in energy engineering from the University of Massachusetts Amherst and a B.Tech from IIT Kharagpur. He received the Ramon Magsaysay Award in 2011, often called Asia's Nobel Prize, for his work in bringing light to those whom the grid forgot. Mr. Hande, welcome to our podcast — it's a privilege to have you here.

Harish Hande: Thank you, Professor, for inviting me. It's an honour to be on this forum.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you. We have very little documented information, even now, on social enterprise leadership — that's part of why we set this up, both to bring these stories to a wider audience, and to create material for future research.

So, in that light, Harish, could you give us a picture of what SELCO Foundation looks like today? Its scale, the communities you serve, your geographies, the nature of your team, and how the organisation is funded?

Harish Hande: There are two organisations, as you mentioned in the introduction. One is SELCO India, which is still running — that's the social enterprise. It's a for-profit social enterprise, but structured so that it's held entirely by three not-for-profits based in the US and Europe — 100% owned by them. As a for-profit, no dividends are ever paid out. Of the profits made each year, 20% is set aside for the bottom 40% of earners in the organisation — the lowest-earning group — as an emergency fund, say, if someone's house is destroyed, or there's a school-fee crisis. Another 20% goes into that same emergency fund, and the remaining 60% goes back into the company for further growth. We've been profitable for the last 18 years.

The SELCO Foundation is different. I think of it this way: Google and Microsoft's biggest subsidy was the internet — if the internet hadn't been built on the back of taxpayer-funded infrastructure, none of what followed would exist. SELCO Foundation's goal is to build that same kind of ecosystem, but for vernacular-based, need-driven sustainable enterprises — a solar-powered roti-rolling machine, a solar-powered silk-weaving machine that improves livelihoods, or innovations around reducing maternal deaths, asking where energy can actually play a role in that chain. The Foundation works in that gap — making livelihoods and health aspirational and futuristic, using decentralised energy, and now AI. We work across about 12 states, mostly the eight states of the Northeast, plus Odisha and North Karnataka. That's the Foundation's focus.

Neharika Vohra: And are there plans to take this to other parts of the country? Because this need exists everywhere.

Harish Hande: Yes — but the primary goal of SELCO is to prove a model that others can then replicate. Honestly, if SELCO itself just keeps growing, that's a problem for me, because the real end goal is that the maximum number of people get these solutions in the shortest possible time — which means more organisations need to be involved in making that happen. So, in a sense, our goal is: should SELCO Foundation even exist after 2035? You're going after a problem, not building an empire.

We didn't pick the Northeast randomly, either — it was a strategic choice, partly because of its sheer diversity, in culture, language, and geography, from the mountains of Meghalaya to the plains of Assam. That makes it a kind of R&D centre for the world. What we do in Assam can be done in the Philippines; what we do in Meghalaya can be done in, say, Ethiopia or Maharashtra. So we picked it deliberately, asking: can this be replicated? What we're trying to create, Professor, are common goods — the same way airports, roads, and schools are common goods. Can we create common goods that can be replicated elsewhere?

Neharika Vohra: Wow, that's a great idea. So, you completed your PhD in the United States, and built a solar energy enterprise in rural India at a time when almost nobody thought that was possible. What drew you to this path? Was there a moment, a person, or a conviction that crystallised the decision for you?

Harish Hande: I think it was really a journey. If you look at my own background — I'm from Rourkela, where my parents didn't have to pay an electricity bill, because it was paid for by the steel plant. Then I went to IIT, subsidised by taxpayers. Then I went to the US on a scholarship. So, standing in front of you, I'm essentially a product of subsidy. And especially at IIT, you're funded by the poor — by people paying tax on salt and sugar. Your original shareholders are the poor. So you start to feel that you didn't study so that you could go and "help" them afterwards — that's not it. You study so you can help build an ecosystem where everybody else gets that same chance.

The second part is that I originally went to the US to look at large-scale solar — could India rely less on foreign oil, and so on. But towards the end of 1990, early '91, I had the chance to go to the Dominican Republic. There, I saw ten houses using small, individual solar systems. A Spanish farmer named Martinez took me inside, explaining it in Spanish, switching the light on and off three times, and said, "See who controls this? I control it, not the utility. I have electricity when I need it." Then he asked if I knew where he'd learned that from. He said, "From India — didn't your leader, Mahatma Gandhi, say that everything lives in the villages, and that people there have to be empowered?" This was a man ten thousand miles away from India. And then he said, "I have a problem with you Indians — you've created everything for the Europeans and the Americans, but whenever I talk to Indians, all they do is complain: this hasn't happened, that hasn't happened. You never take responsibility yourselves." And he said, "I'm telling you this for a specific reason — if India doesn't develop, we don't develop either. We can't learn from the Americans and the Europeans the way the Dominican Republic could learn from India."

That was the moment. I went back to the US and told my professor: nobody's going to read this PhD anyway, so why not actually go and find out what it means, instead of writing about solar energy and electricity I've never lived without myself? That's when I left for Sri Lanka and India, and stayed without electricity for two years. That's where the journey really started.

Neharika Vohra: Wow. So you chose to stay without electricity?

Harish Hande: Yes — because if you don't actually feel what it means, you can do a weekend of "village tourism" and say you understand it, but you don't really feel it. And it wasn't really about solar at all — it was about understanding how people live. If there's a cousin's wedding and you don't have the money, where does the money for the bus ticket actually come from? It's not an Excel-sheet decision. You have to understand the nuances — why people sit in a temple a certain way, why people behave the way they do. Those two years are something I'd never trade for anything else.

Neharika Vohra: Very interesting. And you co-founded this with Neville Williams. How did that founding partnership — bridging an Indian social entrepreneur and an American clean-energy pioneer — shape SELCO's philosophy and direction?

Harish Hande: It happened almost by chance. Neville, at the time, sent me a letter — a lot of young people today wouldn't even know what writing an actual letter means. He was working in Vietnam and other countries, and said he had a small project coming up in India — was I interested? I told him: only if it isn't a "project," because projects are time-bound, and tend to have very little long-term impact — always short-term. Could it instead be something we build a foundation around? He flew to India, we met, and what started out as a non-profit eventually became, "okay, let's set up a company and see what happens." That's how the collaboration with Neville began.

Neharika Vohra: And do you continue to be in touch, or has that collaboration wound down?

Harish Hande: Neville retired a long time ago — he's over 80 now. You know, this is something my wife used to find irritating: when I joined the industry in 1991, the total installed solar capacity in the world was about equivalent to what gets installed in half an hour today. I was the only person under 60 at most of these conferences — I was 24, 25. After we got married, she got quite annoyed, because I started getting more invitations to funerals than anything else! These were legends of true sustainability — people in their 80s and 90s — and I was deeply honoured to have spent time with them.

They were a different breed. Today it's been a bit spoiled by ties and suits, but that original sustainability mindset is something I miss — and those were the people who really mentored me. Neville was one of those pioneers. Paul Maycock, who produced the first solar newsletter back in the '80s, also passed away last year. Dennis Hayes, who founded Earth Day, is still around. These were pioneers, and I was fortunate to have spent time around them.

Neharika Vohra: It's very fortunate to have worked with some of these pioneers. SELCO's model depends on a complex ecosystem — energy entrepreneurs, local financiers, end users, government — a lot of stakeholders to manage. How has that shaped the path SELCO has taken? Have there been moments where, say, a donor or investor's priorities pulled you in a direction you didn't want to go?

Harish Hande: Yes — this did happen. Between around 2000 and 2004–05, when we were struggling as a company, one of our investors collapsed, and the new investor who came in basically wanted the same returns as their investments in the vineyards of France. That's the point where I said: that's something I will not compromise on. It took us 18 months to replace that shareholder —

I can send you a separate case study on exactly how we did it.

There was also an instance where so-called impact investors came in and tried to dictate our business plan. I told them: the business plan is ours, the money is yours — this is a partnership, you don't get to dictate what we do. Not many people say no in that situation. We did. At that point, we had something like one rupee in the bank and 140 people on the payroll. That turned out to be the best “no” we've ever said — because the moment word got around that we'd refused them, three of the five funders who heard about it said, “these guys must be doing something right,” and came forward to invest instead. That's how the three foundations that eventually backed us came in. So my advice is: don't sign on the dotted line just because the temptation is strong.

The second part of your question, Professor, is what SELCO Foundation actually does. Unfortunately, we're known for solar, but out of about 250 people in the Foundation, only two come from an energy background. The rest are systems thinkers, programme designers, agriculture specialists, health workers, dentists, anthropologists. Energy is an enabler — if you're cooking in a restaurant, you don't need a salt expert, you need a *dal* expert. Salt is just there to make things taste better. Solar is just an enabler to make things happen — that's the philosophy behind both organisations.

Neharika Vohra: Very interesting. So you have 250 people on the Foundation's rolls, and around 300 in the enterprise. Tell us a bit more about these people — many of them clearly have very relevant backgrounds for this work. How do you attract them? Foundation salaries presumably can't be the best they could get elsewhere — what are your attrition levels, and how do you keep people motivated?

Harish Hande: I think the filter for us has always been this: our salaries are pegged to street vendors' salaries. What's the ratio between what a street vendor earns and what you earn? If you want to earn more, that ratio has to come down — either you take less, or you find a way to raise what the street vendor earns. That's the real end goal — it's not about how much money you've raised.

Just looking at our salary levels, a lot of people self-select out. We also work on Saturdays, which filters out another set of people. Our reasoning has always been: we'll give ourselves Saturdays off once the poor also get Sundays off. So the real question we put to people at the interview stage is: what are you actually working for? We tell them this upfront — don't complain to me later.

Development work is like a hospital — it runs 24/7. You never know whose crisis is going to land when, and funders give you money for exactly that. It's not like a restaurant that's closed for lunch and dinner. So this can be a genuinely frustrating place to work. We tell people: don't come here if you're trying to build your LinkedIn profile — this isn't that kind of organisation. So, honestly, maybe 20% of people who interview end up being the right fit — we “fail” the interview for the other 80%, for sure.

The people who are actually with us right now, Professor, I hope you get to meet them sometime — especially in the Foundation, it's a young team. The average age is 31, and many of them have been with us 10-plus years; they joined at 19, 20, 21. You'll find India's youngest chartered accountants, LSE graduates, MIT graduates, and 10th-grade dropouts all on the same team — but you won't be able to tell who's the dropout and who's the MIT graduate, because we don't ask people to show their credentials.

You and I might do a PhD on sugarcane and get called experts on sugarcane, while a farmer who's grown sugarcane for 40 years is never called an expert. We wanted to break that myth around inclusivity. Some of our programme managers are quite young, but already have 14, 15 years of SELCO experience behind them — they're just not very visible outside the organisation.

Neharika Vohra: And these teams — since you're spread across so many states, they must be in very different locations too, not all in one place.

Harish Hande: In Bangalore we have around 80 people, but we also have offices in Manipur, in Shillong, Meghalaya, then in Mizoram, in Bodoland, Assam, in Pasighat, Arunachal Pradesh, then Kalahandi in South Odisha, Bhubaneswar, and North Karnataka in Dharwad — and across all of them, the people are largely drawn from those regions themselves.

Neharika Vohra: But you must have some integrating mechanisms for people who are spread out like that — how do you build a SELCO culture, or have people stay aligned with SELCO's DNA, without necessarily “abiding” by some fixed script?

Harish Hande: Honestly, it's about a 50-50 hit rate — that's a question we grapple with every six months or so. There are regular meets, people travel frequently, but more than anything, it's the induction process that matters. It isn't a classroom exercise — “this is what SELCO does.” Until you've actually shadowed someone — say, in North Karnataka, which is one of our most mature regions — you don't really get it. So we'll bring someone from Mizoram and base them out of Dharwad for a while, and we're upfront that 99% of what we do in Dharwad might not be directly relevant in Mizoram. Take only the underlying principles — learn the Pythagoras theorem, so to speak — because the soil conditions for actually building the bridge will be completely different in Mizoram.

So it's genuinely a 50-50 split — either people stay for 10, 15, 20 years, or they leave within three months; there isn't much in between, it's quite clear-cut. The highest attrition we see is among people who join straight out of a master's programme, and the hardest part has been the unlearning — particularly for people who've spent five years in the corporate sector. Poverty is so unstructured that you have to think on your feet constantly — is this a financial problem, a technology issue, a business-model issue, who are the stakeholders involved? In the corporate world, you're usually selling a defined product within a defined structure, and that kind of open-ended thinking can be genuinely hard to build.

Neharika Vohra: That's amazing — I can see it being a genuinely complex problem to crack, not an easy one. But you do need some of those corporate-trained people, I'd imagine, to help build that diversity of expertise.

Harish Hande: Right — because once you've built an innovation, the people who built it usually aren't the right people to scale it; left in their hands alone, it tends to fizzle out. So, very simply: say you build a roti-rolling machine and work with 10 or 15 entrepreneurs to formalise it, and then work with a bank to design an innovative financing scheme so women in that area can access it — maybe linking it to a government scheme like the PMFI scheme, with a 15% subsidy for people with disabilities. That's stage one. Stage two is: can I go to a bank and turn this into a standardised product — say, under the Mudra loan scheme — so a roti-rolling machine becomes a standard, fundable product? How do I work with four or five banks to make that happen? Stage three is: can I work with NABARD and the RBI to institutionalise this completely, and take it to the next level? You need a different kind of person at each of those stages.

Neharika Vohra: Sure — and then manufacturing it at scale too, at some point.

Harish Hande: Exactly — that's when you work with the enterprise making the roti-rolling machine, not just to design it for different users, say, people with disabilities who can't travel easily, but also to make it genuinely aspirational. How do you help them design something more like a washing machine, as a finished product, rather than a roti-rolling machine that looks like a rusted iron contraption after a while? You work with the enterprise to make it aspirational too.

Neharika Vohra: How do you actually hear from the customer, or from the people you're innovating for? How is that connection maintained within the organisation, because I think that's really the heart of it?

Harish Hande: Exactly the right question. We organise around portfolios — two primary ones are livelihoods and health. On the livelihoods side, we have four areas: agriculture, animal husbandry, resilient micro-businesses (tailors, barber shops, eateries), and textiles and crafts.

Take animal husbandry as an example. In North Karnataka, poultry and dairy are the primary forms of animal husbandry — take dairy. We look at the whole chain: fodder, the cowshed, the cows themselves, milking, storage, and then khoya-making. Where does energy play a role in each of those? It's not about starting from a solar panel and working backwards from a demo product. So you get things like solar-powered hydroponics for fodder; cowsheds that are badly designed cause heat stress that can cut milk yield by up to 30%, so we redesign them — we actually have eight architects in our office for exactly this reason.

Bad building design often means you end up needing more solar panels than you should. Think of a maternity ward designed like an execution chamber — if you design it well, with proper daylighting and airflow, you maintain something closer to 29 degrees rather than heat stress above 42, and you end up needing far less solar capacity. So it's never really about the solar — it's about everything around it.

Coming back to dairy: solar-powered hydroponics means better fodder; better fodder means better milk; redesigned cowsheds reduce heat stress; solar-powered milking machines reduce drudgery; solar-powered chilling lets farmers actually store the milk; solar-powered khoya-making adds value further down the chain. So if I go to the Karnataka Milk Federation, which has around 3,000 farmers under it, and lay out these eight interventions — one farmer might take three, another might take all eight — suddenly you're working at scale. Rather than going farmer by farmer with a solar panel, you go cooperative by cooperative — suddenly the Karnataka Milk Federation is talking to Maharashtra's federation, or to Amul, about doing this together. That's how energy gets institutionalised into these systems.

The trouble with energy, generally, is that it's always approached from the supply side — not by asking who the stakeholders on the demand side actually are. Organisations like Amul, or the Karnataka Milk Federation, will hand you the real problem statements: "Boss, our milking machine isn't working properly." A bank will tell you the roti-rolling machine financing isn't landing the way it should. It's not only the end user who can frame the real problem — the institutions directly connected to end users can do that too.

Neharika Vohra: Got it, got it. When you put it that way, it sounds almost common-sensical — why would it be any other way? But I think that's the beauty of good systems thinking. I'm curious, though: how does your organisation actually work day to day — who's coming up with these ideas, who's working on what, how does that play out internally?

Harish Hande: If you imagine an X-Y axis: the top-right quadrant is the systems-level question — what’s the underlying system problem you’re trying to solve? We sometimes avoid even using the word “problem,” because “problem” implies a gap, and “gap” tends to skip over an earlier question — like, is the grid even the right solution at all, today? That’s systems-level thinking. Something like: a hundred thousand people need to be settled around Vastrapur, in Ahmedabad — that’s my problem, framed at the systems level.

Then you move diagonally down towards the middle, into programmes — transportation, livelihoods, and so on. Say there are 20,000 people, there’s a river, and you need two bridges because of where people will live and move — that’s a programme. Then you come down to projects: those two bridges are the project. The project connects to the programme, and the programme connects to the system-level goal. Otherwise, what happens in a lot of CSR work today is: “Professor, you’re great at building bridges — can you build two more?” Nobody asks whether it’s actually needed. The original bridge mattered because it connected to where people lived, and ultimately to that hundred thousand people.

So the ratio we try to maintain is something like 2 to 4% systems thinkers — if everyone were a systems thinker, no actual work would get done. Then 5 to 8% programme designers. Then about 70% project implementers — people who say, “Don’t give me a system, just give me a bridge, and I’ll build it.”

Here’s a useful test, Professor: you can often predict how a meeting will go just by who you send to it. If you send someone to the Chief Secretary and say, “I need to build two hospitals,” she’ll say, “fine, I’ll connect you to someone else, go do it” — you should have gone in with a systems-level lens, talking about what you’re actually trying to achieve. If you go to a District Health Officer and start talking about changing the entire state’s health system, they’ll say, “what are you even talking about — just tell me about the two hospitals.” You should be talking projects there. So even what you want out of a meeting requires systems-level thinking about who to send — that’s essentially how we’ve structured the organisation: who’s at the systems level, who’s a programme designer, who’s a project implementer.

Neharika Vohra: That’s very interesting, and very insightful. So moving on from there, to this whole idea of SELCO to SELCO Foundation, which does all the innovation work — I also read about the failure conference you hold. Is it every year?

Harish Hande: Every two years, yes.

Neharika Vohra: This whole idea of being innovative having to be linked to a comfort with, and an acceptance of, failure — can you share a bit more about that?

Harish Hande: The failure conference came out of pure frustration. If you look at impact reports from funders, CSR programmes, foreign or Indian philanthropy — and added up everyone’s claimed impact — it would come to about three times India’s population. And every single report reads as fantastic, amazing. That, in a way, is actually a disservice to the next generation. It’s not about dwelling on failure for its own sake — it’s: “Boss, I’ve travelled this road, there are four potholes on it — make sure you avoid them.” That’s all I’m really saying. And sugar-coating things is just as much of a problem — either tell me what actually failed, as it is, and let’s deal with it together, or don’t bother telling me at all.

Even with successes — say I build a railway line between Delhi and Ahmedabad, and the train, the carriages, everything about it is fantastic, but between Meerut and Delhi a different soil condition causes the tracks to fail. Normally, we’d just call the whole project a failure. But that same track might succeed brilliantly in Karnataka, where the soil conditions are completely different. So the real lesson might be: 90% was fine, it’s that 10% soil condition that needs addressing. Was it a failure, a partial failure, a complete failure? Tell me as it actually is.

So we decided to be bold about it, and started by presenting SELCO’s own failures, on a panel, in front of all our funders. The first question I asked my colleagues preparing for it was: what is it that you normally don’t tell your funders? Because all the funders are sitting right there in the audience — which funders do you not particularly enjoy working with, and why? Be straightforward. And we asked the funders the same question in return: which failures are you willing to take responsibility for yourselves, rather than simply blaming the grantee?

The first year was the hardest, because a lot of people didn’t want to speak without sugar-coating it — some of the multilateral agencies actually refused outright, saying they had no business talking about failure in public. By the time we got to the third edition, it gained a lot of traction, once people realised funders really were sitting right there listening. Rachita and Huda curated it brilliantly — they prepared people, telling them, “just say it as it is, and let the audience figure out the solutions.”

Vijay Mahajan came for the first one, and gave a presentation about how he himself was responsible for losing \$100 million — incredibly bold. Chintan Vaishnav, who headed India’s Atal Innovation Mission, talked about the kinds of “diseases” we suffer from in innovation — something like “delay-itis, not my-baby-itis” — and that gave a lot of confidence to the younger people in the room.

Neharika Vohra: And you continue to run that?

Harish Hande: Yes — the next one is in 2027, and we're shifting the format slightly. People have talked plenty about failures, but we also want to know: what was the actual consequence of that failure, and who bore it? People often say, "I learned from it and moved on" — but in our sector, the biggest brunt of failure usually falls on the poor. You might say, "I failed in Sri Lanka, so I fixed it in Bangladesh" — but what happened to the people in Sri Lanka in the meantime? So the next conference is going to focus on the consequences of failure, and who actually bears that cost.

Neharika Vohra: And this is something you run in Bangalore, is it?

Harish Hande: Yes, every two years. It's also, in a way, a bit of a comedy show — that's part of the point, actually: how do you normalise talking about failure?

Neharika Vohra: That is so important. Honestly, as a country, we're very cagey about failure, so that's a real issue. You've also been an outspoken critic of the mainstream development sector's top-down approach to energy, and possibly other things too. How have you navigated the institutional and reputational risks of challenging a dominant narrative in the field?

Harish Hande: I think it comes down to real clarity about your end goal. Ours has always been very clear: who are you actually representing? The voiceless. You're in a privileged position, so the real question is — are you speaking for yourself, for your organisation, or for the end user? If it's for the end user, you'd better be very clear about what they're actually saying. That's where the problem usually starts: people get on panels and talk about personal or organisational achievements. That might be fine in the private sector, but in this sector, you're supposed to be talking about the problems of the sector — what needs solving, how to solve it — not your own LinkedIn profile, but the sector's collective profile, so to speak.

And ultimately, if someone comes along and says, "I learned from you, but I'm going to do it better than you did," that, to us, is what success actually looks like. If Turing hadn't built the first computer, we wouldn't have the iPad today — it's not that old technology becomes obsolete, it's that it gets built on. So the real test for expensive philanthropic and taxpayer-backed CSR money is: does someone else end up doing it better, having learned from you, rather than simply copying what you did?

That's also why I focus on ratios. People sometimes assume I'm against paying good salaries — I'm not. If you're taking that salary, deliver the impact that matches it. In the private sector, your pay is tied to what you deliver, otherwise the business loses money. Here, it has to be tied to the number of people you're actually impacting relative to what you're paid. It's not about taking less — it's about making sure your impact scales to match what you take, by something like a factor of fifty. It's not about how much capital you've raised; that's not the right measure at all.

People sometimes assume our brand is very strong on the funding side, but we really only work closely with about five dedicated funding partners, and frankly, none of them want their name attached publicly. We're upfront in our proposals that there's a 90% chance we'll fail. My colleagues have a monthly call with each of them, and in at least four of those relationships, it's a genuine back-and-forth — half the time we're presenting, half the time they are, sharing how things have moved forward. It's a real partnership: it might be your money, but we share the same end goal — so you take the credit, and you also take the brunt of the failure, together.

Neharika Vohra: So building on what you just said — your hope, or rather your conviction, was that if India could do this, other countries could learn from it and do it too. Has that happened?

Harish Hande: Yes — and actually, on your last question too: we tend to jump quickly into criticism, saying the government doesn't work, this doesn't work, that doesn't work. But that's not really true — there are champions everywhere: in government, in academia, in the corporate sector. A blanket criticism isn't useful. So what we try to do is find those champions, and ask: can we actually work alongside them? People like Shalini Goel, the present Chief Secretary of Karnataka, or Sampat Kumar and Ram Kumar, who are IAS officers in Meghalaya — during COVID, I used to say, if officers like these weren't doing what they do, this country would be in serious trouble. Sampat Kumar or Shalini Goel would text me at four in the morning asking what to do. There are critical, deeply committed people in every sector — and that's partly what's kept us sane: there are people you can genuinely work with, even while being critical of the system as a whole, and ask, how do we actually move forward together?

That's also part of why we've been clear about critiquing the top-down approach: philanthropic capital could be used far better if it went directly to whichever stakeholder can move the biggest needle on a given problem, rather than to whichever stakeholder happens to write the most polished proposal. Otherwise you end up in a kind of beauty contest over whose proposal reads better, which isn't the point at all. So we've been very direct: this is what it is — if you want to fund this, partner with us properly. We won't compromise just to get, say, a nice photo opportunity. That's cheesy, and frankly it ends up patronising poverty, which is an insult to the very people you're meant to be serving.

Neharika Vohra: Absolutely — sorry, I'd lost my train of thought there for a moment — yes, other countries, that's right.

Harish Hande: Other countries — for example, we have a relationship with the International Solar Alliance, and they asked whether we could look at Ethiopia, Tanzania, Uganda, and Rwanda. We were very clear that we weren't going to open offices in those countries, because we believe there's already immense talent there. A lot of these countries went straight from colonisation into a kind of “donor colonisation,” where outside donors end up deciding everything. So instead, we proposed South-South cooperation — what can actually be shared?

For example, there's a large pastoral community in the lowland areas of Ethiopia, so we connected them with the work we've already done with pastoral communities in Rajasthan — looking at, say, a camel value chain, much like we looked at the dairy value chain earlier. In Uganda and Tanzania, it's fisheries — similar to what we're already doing in South Odisha and Assam. On health, what we're doing in the Northeast around maternal health — by 2030, we'd like institutions like Boston Medical College to be learning from Mizoram, and from Ethiopia, rather than the other way round, because Boston carries the baggage of legacy infrastructure that we can leapfrog, using AI and decentralised energy. So those are the kinds of linkages we're building.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful — that's possibly the way forward for all of us: to actually work together and learn from each other.

Harish Hande: And I tell young consultants who are graduating and want to join the big consulting firms: build your own thing instead. Don't just look at Europe and the US — India's own policy diversity, across Delhi, Karnataka, Kerala, Meghalaya, is incredibly rich. It's not like a set of Lego pieces; it's more like the variables in a formula. Pick the right elements from Jammu and Kashmir, Delhi, and Meghalaya, and that combination might solve sixty percent of what a country like Sierra Leone needs. So rather than chasing the “Big Four” or “Big Five,” build a vernacular-based consultancy — Garo-speaking, for instance — and that expertise and knowledge can then be replicated for Swahili-speaking contexts too. With AI, we should be able to do that now.

Neharika Vohra: Definitely — we're able to do it now, that should make it easier for all of us. Of course, AI's problem is that it's so dependent on written language — a lot of oral knowledge and wisdom simply isn't captured in it at all. That's a separate issue. So, coming back to community and social leadership — you mentioned earlier that you spent two years really immersing yourself, trying to understand and empathise, which must have helped enormously with trust-building. Over the years, how have you gone about building trust with the communities you work with?

Harish Hande: That really depends on who your colleagues are. The kind of colleagues we have in Mizoram, or in Meghalaya — many of them come from those communities themselves. It's about choosing people who can have one foot here and one foot there — who might not be in daily contact with the community, but can switch sides comfortably when it matters.

If I think of three building blocks — the funder, SELCO, and the community — there are gaps between each pair. What matters is identifying the people who overlap between, say, the funder and SELCO, who can move between the two and say, “this will actually work,” or “this won't.” The same goes between SELCO and the community. Those buffer people are absolutely critical — without them, it just becomes transactional. Are we actually able to switch sides — to say, “I understand exactly where you're coming from,” but also, “wait, this proposal isn't actually good for you”?

Those buffer people are the ones who really make an organisation successful — it isn't about negotiation, it's about buffering. I tell people: when you go and present to, say, a funder in Delhi, you're representing the community in that room. Equally, can the community represent SELCO elsewhere?

Neharika Vohra: Fascinating — the closest concept I've heard to this is “brokers” in network theory, but what you're describing is much richer than brokering or connecting. You're talking about people who can almost become interchangeable across these different groups.

Harish Hande: Exactly, exactly — and some people simply can't do this, no matter how much empathy they have, because of how they dress, or because of their own background. I remember once, Elaben — Ela Bhatt, the founder of SEWA — visited, and we were sitting in our house, and she said, “Harish Bhai, after 60 years, I once asked the women I work with: do you think I'm one of you?” And they said no — because of something as simple as how she wore her sandals. After 60 years.

So what I tell some of our younger colleagues is: it's great that you want to work directly with communities, but stay within your own strengths, and don't force yourself into that role. It's not that the community won't trust you — but the answers you get back will end up being purely transactional, and you'll never get past that.

Neharika Vohra: Very interesting — so you're also saying you're careful about who you choose as that buffer, and there's real nurturing and mentoring involved in developing that person, since not everyone is suited to it — and that's no judgement on the people who aren't. You've also engaged with global platforms — the UN, international climate forums, global impact networks.

How important are these networks to SELCO's work, and how do they actually feed back into your grassroots programmes in Karnataka, Odisha, and the Northeast?

Harish Hande: These networks are mostly useful on the connections side — they're one of the cheapest ways to find out what's happening, model-wise, in other countries. Though I'd take a lot of that with a pinch of salt, because so much of that articulation comes from a fairly English-centric point of view. What you get is a small window — maybe 5% of the real picture — but if that 5% opens up a connection, say, between what's happening in Kalahandi and something similar in Uganda, I can send a colleague to go and see it firsthand. That 5% is really what we're after.

It's the cheapest way to connect with the 20, 30, 40, 50 people who've worked across different contexts, and build relationships from there — useful for what I'd call the "amplification" category. Again, I don't want to paint every large organisation with one brush — there are genuine champions inside UNDP, UN bilateral agencies, GIZ, and so on. If I find one of those champions, say, someone doing great work for GIZ in India, my goal isn't to figure out how they can fund SELCO. My goal is: where is this person going next? If they move to Uganda or Tanzania, can they carry that thinking forward, so people there benefit too? For example, one colleague, Michael, once reached out for our documentation on fisheries for a project in the Philippines, because he recognised the same systemic need there — that saved an organisation like GIZ a lot of time, and more people in the Philippines ultimately benefited. That's amplification: can you help large funders start thinking systemically? Because if they do, the needle moves faster — and for us, that's the real goal, not just our own direct impact.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice. So the whole idea, really, is about not wasting resources, given how scarce they already are. Very interesting. So, Harish, how have you stayed motivated through all of this? You clearly still are — what keeps you going?

Harish Hande: I think about it almost like preparing for an entrance exam — you wake up at three in the morning because one problem is still nagging at you. In this field, no matter how many years you've put in, a new problem lands on the table, and no amount of Google searching, or your PhD, is going to solve it for you, because the variables are different every single time.

There's an example I often share, from years ago. Two women came running into one of our labs during heavy rain, both in tears, saying they only had two saris between them, and because they couldn't dry properly, their bodies would smell — and that's why, they believed, their husbands were having affairs. Please save our marriages, they said. No electricity, pouring rain — your PhD is irrelevant at that point, Google is no help either. How do you even formulate that as a problem, let alone solve it? A similar issue comes up in Gujarat, where water scarcity means people can't properly wash clothes. These are very basic, real things — you can Google a problem statement and get a hundred apps back, but for problems like these, the formulation itself doesn't even exist yet, let alone the solution.

So how do you build that kind of empathy, operating on a completely different level? I keep telling younger colleagues: if you're not frustrated, you'll never stay motivated. You have to let yourself get frustrated, because it's very easy to give up otherwise — frustration is what keeps the energy going. If someone complains that a pipe is leaking and blames the government, I say, fine — give me five possible solutions, and I'll personally take them to the Bangalore Municipal Commissioner. That's usually when people step back, because there's no such thing as a "stupid" solution — the only real problem is the habit of simply saying no, or giving up too soon.

Neharika Vohra: Very interesting. So in retrospect, are there one or two things you'd do differently now, Harish?

Harish Hande: Honestly, no, not really. If there's one thing, it's that I'd have engaged the younger generation faster — maybe five to ten years earlier than I actually did. The ratio of youngsters we engage with today, against what's actually needed, is something like a hundred to one. If we'd started this in 1999 instead of 2004, far more young people would already be part of this systems-thinking pipeline today.

The real issue is that people get bogged down in individual projects. The question is, are we building a pipeline of young people, by 2030, who genuinely think in systems, whether they're 18 years old in Sirsi, in Dahod, or in rural Tanzania? That's still the missing piece — we're still grappling with how we should have started this earlier.

Neharika Vohra: But you've had some success with it, even though you started a bit late.

Harish Hande: Yes — though the biggest structural barrier, Professor, is how we're trained academically. I'm a mechanical engineer; you're electrical — "this is the computer science department's job," people say. But would a tomato vendor ever get to say, "tomato prices have gone up, sorry, I won't sell potatoes because I'm a tomato specialist"? That's the kind of silo we need to break down — these rigid academic boundaries around what's "in syllabus" and what isn't.

If you look at most IIMs or IITs, the real question is: how do you build genuinely cross-cutting teams? You need an engineer, an architect, a finance person, and a grassroots worker all on the same team, treated as equal partners — not as specialists simply handing work off to each other.

Neharika Vohra: Very good — bringing in real difference like that, and that’s genuinely difficult; I think it’s only getting harder, not easier.

Harish Hande: Yes — because everyone’s become territorial: “this is my forte,” and nothing else.

Neharika Vohra: One more question — one of the biggest risks for organisations like yours is succession planning, because you’re so deeply committed to this work. Who’s next in line? Are you thinking about it, planning for it? Not that you need to go anywhere anytime soon, but how do you approach this?

Harish Hande: If you came to Bangalore, you’d find I’m only one of 25 signing authorities in the organisation, and I have zero personal connections to any of our funders — not a single one. The only connection funders really have to me is at a strategic level — say, an evaluator working with a funder like IKEA might call to ask where their funding should go next. But operationally, I haven’t had a single operational meeting in the last three years. Zero.

So the real question I keep pushing on is: what’s the succession plan for the three or four colleagues who actually run things day to day? They’re in their mid-thirties, well known in their own right — Huda, Rachita, Rucha, and Nikhil are all extremely capable and well-respected, and they joined when they were in their twenties — they’ve each been in the organisation for about 15 years now. Once you actually engage with SELCO, you realise it’s never really been about what Harish wants. I’m not joking. Five, ten years ago, we already said: founder syndrome is a real, ridiculous problem across the civil-society sector.

That’s also where civil-society organisations tend to collapse — when funders end up dictating everything from the top down. So what do you learn from people like Elaben, or from organisations like PRADAN, about how to actually distribute leadership? At this point, honestly, the succession of SELCO Foundation is the least of my worries. We tell others too: just say it plainly — “boss, this failed, that failed” — don’t dress it up. The curation of our failure conference, for instance, is entirely done by Rachita and Huda.

Neharika Vohra: I see. And what keeps you busy now, then?

Harish Hande: More of a South-South strategic question, really. India has had this huge wealth of social movements — the independence movement, the SEWA movement, agrarian movements, and so on — in a way that simply doesn’t exist in many African countries.

For instance, I was once talking to a lift operator in Uganda, and asked him what he did — and what he said really stuck with me: isn’t that true empowerment, in a way? Because for him, that job simply was what it was — the most capable people there ended up in that role, without the layered hierarchy of jobs that we have here. So one question is, how do you break that deeply ingrained, almost colonised way of ranking work and people? The second is building ecosystems for vernacular languages — who actually gets funded tends to be whoever can produce a slick PowerPoint or Word document in English. How do you build space for Garo-speaking, Swahili-speaking, Oriya-speaking entrepreneurs to access the same resources?

The third thing I’m working on, with Chintan Bhai, is almost about recipes — recipes that used to pass from grandmother to mother to daughter, purely orally, and that whole transmission has been disrupted now that everything has to be written down. A lot of that knowledge is simply dying out, because it never gets passed on anymore. Think about it this way: when a tribal person from Odisha ends up working as a driver in a villa in Bangalore, that isn’t upskilling — that’s de-skilling someone by roughly eight generations. Their knowledge of paddy farming, of the forest, just disappears.

So what we’re asking is: can we, by 2030, document a million voices? Not just written records — actual recorded voices, from tribal communities especially, talking through their own knowledge, so we don’t lose it entirely. The beauty of AI here is that, earlier, you’d have needed an enormous manual survey effort just to capture and record all of this — now AI can actually help put it to genuinely good use. Imagine documenting a million voices across Odisha and the Northeast, and two million more across Swahili-speaking regions — the world’s understanding of forestry knowledge alone would be transformed. That’s the kind of programme I’m working on.

Neharika Vohra: Yes, yes — that’s lovely, and all strength and power to you for doing that. So, this is really my last question, and it’s for the younger listeners — is there any advice, anything you think they should keep in mind as they think about their careers, or about working in this sector?

Harish Hande: I think the usual advice is, “you need clarity” — but actually, I’d say the opposite. If you’re genuinely confused at this age, that’s a good thing, because it means you still have multiple paths open to you. And when you’re at what feels like the least “responsible” point in your life — before marriage, before other obligations pile up — that’s exactly the time to take a few real risks.

Take the unreserved train compartment from Dhanbad to Calcutta, so to speak — don't jump straight into a fixed organisational career from day one, because five or ten years later, you'll find yourself thinking, "I wanted to do this, but I never had the time." My advice to young people: experiment for the next three years of your life before deciding you're going to join, say, one of the Big Four. That's actually what I was telling you earlier, Professor — the biggest disadvantage that large institutions like the IIMs and IITs create is the placement department itself.

Because once there's a placement department, you're herded — eighty percent of people just follow that track. My question is: where are you actually letting young people explore? Go now — and remember, you have the safety net of your education to fall back on after three years. And for young people outside the typical English-speaking, urban track, we're trying to build something similar — spaces like the one we're building in Sirsi, Dharwad.

In Sirsi, we're essentially creating a maker space for young farmers to come and fail, safely. Use those next two or three years, at that age, to build your real foundation — and that foundation isn't a degree from an IIT or an IIM, or even necessarily from farming itself. It's about spending real time on something you'll genuinely never have the time for again, later in life.

Neharika Vohra: That's so true — especially given all the privilege a lot of us have, not having to take care of parents or other responsibilities just yet.

Harish Hande: Right, right — the safety nets are there.

Neharika Vohra: Exactly — they are. But this has been wonderful — thank you so much for talking with us, and for helping us understand your work in a bit more depth. We wish you all the best with whatever you take on next — the Million Voices project sounds like a truly wonderful thing to be working on. Thank you, and hopefully we'll meet again.

Harish Hande: Absolutely. Thank you.